

MELINIS
SYN. RHYNCHELYTRUM
POACEAE/GRAMINEAE
See also GRASSES, BAMBOOS, RUSHES, and SEDGES.
M. repens , syn. <i>Rhynchelytrum repens</i> , <i>R. roseum</i> (Natal grass). Tuft-forming, annual or short-lived perennial grass. H 18–48in (45–120cm), S 24–36in (60–100cm). Leaves are mid-green, flat, and finely pointed. Produces loose panicles of awned, bright purple to rose-red spikelets from midsummer to early fall. Z10–11
MELIOSMA
SABIACEAE/MELIOSMACEAE
Genus of evergreen and deciduous trees and shrubs, grown for their habit, foliage, and flowers (which are not produced reliably). Fully hardy to frost hardy. Prefers full sun and deep, fertile, well-drained soil. Propagate by seed in fall.
M. oldhamii . See <i>M. pinnata</i> var. <i>oldhamii</i> .
M. pinnata var. <i>oldhamii</i> , syn. <i>M. oldhamii</i> . Deciduous, stout-branched tree, upright when young, spreading when mature. H 30ft (10m), S 20ft (6m). Has very large, dark green leaves divided into 5–13 ovate leaflets. Bears large clusters of small, fragrant, star-shaped, white flowers in early summer. Z8–10
M. veitchiorum illus. p.74.
MELITTIS
<i>Bastard balm</i>
LAMIACEAE/LABIATAE
Genus of one species of summer-flowering perennial, grown for its 2-lipped flowers. Fully hardy. Needs light shade and fertile, well-drained soil. Propagate by seed in fall or by division in spring.
M. melissophyllum illus. p.264.
MELOCACTUS
<i>Turk's cap</i>
CACTACEAE
Genus of spherical, rarely elongated, ribbed, perennial cacti that occasionally branch. On reaching flowering size, usually 6in (15cm) high, stems produce woolly crowns; then stems appear to stop growing while woolly crowns develop into columns. Has funnel-shaped flowers in summer, followed by elongated or rounded, red, pink, or white seed pods. Frost tender. Needs a site in full sun and extremely well-drained soil. Propagate by seed in spring.
M. actinacanthus . See <i>M. matanzanus</i> .
M. bahiensis . Spherical, perennial cactus. H and S 6in (15cm). Dull green stem bears 10–15 ribs. Produces stout, slightly curved, dark brown spines that become paler with age. Crown bears brown bristles and pink flowers, ½–¾in (1–2cm) across, in summer. Z12 (min. 61°F/16°C)
M. communis . See <i>M. intortus</i> .
M. curvispinus , syn. <i>M. oaxacensis</i> . Spherical to columnar, perennial cactus. H 8in (20cm), S 6in (15cm). Green stem has 10–15 rounded ribs. Areoles each bear 1–2 straight central spines and 8–12 curved radial spines. Flat, woolly crown bears deep pink flowers in summer. Z12 (min. 61°F/16°C)

M. intortus, syn. *M. communis* (Melon cactus), illus. p.494.

M. matanzanus, syn. *M. actinacanthus*. Spherical, perennial cactus. H and S 4in (10cm). Dark green stem has neat, short spines and develops a woolly crown about 5 years from seed. In summer, produces pink flowers, ½in (1cm) across. Z12 (min. 61°F/16°C)

M. oaxacensis. See *M. curvispinus*.

MENISPERMUM

Moonseed

MENISPERMACEAE

Genus of deciduous, sometimes semiwoody, twining, suckering climbers, grown for their attractive fruits that each contain a crescent-shaped seed—hence the common name. Male and female flowers are borne on separate plants; to produce fruits, plants of both sexes must be grown. Fully hardy. Grow in sun and in any well-drained soil. Propagate by seed in fall or suckers in fall or spring. ☉Fruits may cause severe discomfort if ingested.

M. canadense (Canada moonseed, Yellow parilla). Vigorous, deciduous, usually woody-stemmed, twining climber, producing a dense tangle of stems and spreading by underground suckers. H to 15ft (5m). Ovate to heart-shaped, rounded leaves are usually 3–7-lobed. Has small, cup-shaped, greenish-yellow flowers in summer, then poisonous, spherical, glossy, blackish fruits. Z4–8

MENTHA

Mint

LAMIACEAE/LABIATAE

Genus of rhizomatous perennials, some of which are semievergreen, rarely annuals, grown for their aromatic foliage, which is both decorative and used as a culinary herb. Plants are invasive, however, and should be used with caution. Fully hardy. Grow in a sunny or shady position and in well-drained soil. Propagate by division in spring or fall.

M. citrata. See *M. × piperita* f. *citrata*.

M. corsica. See *M. requienii*.

M. odorata. See *M. × piperita* f. *citrata*.

M. × piperita f. *citrata*, syn. *M. citrata*, *M. odorata*, *M. piperita* var. *citriodora*, (Eau-de-Cologne mint, Lemon mint) is a vigorous, spreading perennial. H 1–2ft (30–60cm), S 2ft (60cm). Reddish-green stems, bearing terminal spikes of small, 2-lipped, purple flowers in summer, arise from a carpet of ovate, slightly toothed, mid-green leaves that have a scent which is similar to *eau de Cologne*. Z4–9. ‘**Basil**’ has peppermint- and basil-scented leaves. ‘**Chocolate**’ has dark brown-flushed leaves that smell of peppermint and chocolate; excellent as a garnish for desserts. Leaves of ‘**Lime**’ are slightly purple-flushed, with a lime scent.

M. piperita var. *citriodora*. See

M. × piperita f. *citrata*.

M. requienii, syn. *M. corsica* (Corsican mint). Semievergreen, mat-forming, creeping perennial. H to ½in (1cm), S indefinite. When crushed, the rounded, bright apple-green leaves exude a strong peppermint scent. Bears tiny, stemless, lavender-purple flowers in summer.

Suitable for a rock garden or paved path. Needs shade and moist soil. Z4–9

M. rotundifolia of gardens. See *M.*

suaveolens.

M. spicata, syn. *M. viridis* (Spearmint).

Spreading perennial. H to 3ft (1m), S indefinite. Aromatic, lance-shaped to ovate, toothed, bright green leaves, are sometimes hairy beneath. In summer, bears dense, cylindrical spikes of whorls of tiny, pink, lilac, or white flowers. Z3–7.

‘**Moroccan**’ (Moroccan mint), H 16in (40cm), has very aromatic, mid-green leaves.

‘**Tashkent**’, H 32in (80cm), has ovate, strongly aromatic leaves; rust resistant.

M. suaveolens, syn. *M. rotundifolia* of gardens (Apple mint). ‘**Variegata**’ (Variegated apple mint) illus. p.274.

M. viridis. See *M. spicata*.

MENTZELIA

Starflower

LOASACEAE

Genus of hairy, spreading to erect, freely branching, annuals, biennials, perennials, and evergreen subshrubs. Fully hardy to frost tender. Requires sun and fertile, very well-drained soil; tender species are best grown in pots under glass. Propagate by seed in spring; shrubs also by semiripe cuttings in summer.

M. lindleyi, syn. *Bartonia aurea* (Blazing star). Fairly fast-growing, bushy annual. H 1½ft (45cm), S 8in (20cm). Has fleshy stems and lance-shaped to ovate, serrated leaves. In summer, bears night-scented, cup-shaped, deep yellow flowers, flushed orange at the bases, with conspicuous stamens. Z5–10

MENYANTHES

MENYANTHACEAE

Genus of deciduous, perennial, marginal water plants, grown for their foliage and flowers. Fully hardy. Prefers an open, sunny position. Remove fading flower heads and foliage, and divide overcrowded clumps in spring. Propagate by seed in winter or divide rhizomes in summer.

M. trifoliata (Bog bean) illus. p.434.

Menziesia cilicalyx var. **purpurea**.

See *Rhododendron multiflorum* var. *purpureum*.

MERENDERA

COLCHICACEAE/LILIACEAE

Genus of bulbs grown for their foliage and flowers. Fully hardy to half hardy. Grow in a raised bed, alpine house, or bulb frame; *M. montana* is suitable for a sunny rock garden. Water moderately in the growing season. Plants require a hot, dry period of summer dormancy. Propagate by seed in spring or fall, or by offsets during summer dormancy.

M. bulbocodium. See *M. montana*.

M. caucasica. See *M. trigyna*.

M. eichleri. See *M. trigyna*.

M. montana, syn. *Colchicum montanum*, *M. bulbocodium*, *M. pyrenaica*. Fall-flowering bulb. H and S 5cm (2in). Has 3 or 4 linear, channeled leaves, to 9in (22cm) long, produced with or after the

1 or 2 upright, funnel-shaped, purple to red-purple flowers, sometimes with white bases. Z5–9

M. pyrenaica. See *M. montana*.

M. raddeana. See *M. trigyna*.

M. trigyna, syn. *Colchicum trigynum*, *M. caucasica*, *M. eichleri*, *M. raddeana*. Spring-flowering bulb. H and S 2in (5cm). Produces linear to lance-shaped leaves, to 7in (17cm) long, at the same time as 1–3 funnel-shaped, purple-pink to white flowers, with narrow petals. Z4–9

MERREMIA

CONVOLVULACEAE

Genus of deciduous, sometimes evergreen, woody, twining climbers, grown for their flowers and fruits. Frost tender. Prefers fertile, well-drained soil and full light. Water moderately, much less when not in full growth. Provide support. Thin out congested stems during spring. Propagate by seed in spring. Red spider mite may be a problem.

M. tuberosa, syn. *Ipomoea tuberosa*, *Operculina tuberosa* (Spanish morning glory, Wood rose, Yellow morning glory). Fast-growing, evergreen, twining climber. H 20ft (6m) or more. Leaves have 5-7 lobes. In summer, bears funnel-shaped, yellow flowers, followed by semiwoody, round, ivory-brown fruits. Z10–12 (min. 45–50°F/7–10°C)

MERTENSIA

BORAGINACEAE

Genus of clump- or mound-forming or prostrate perennials, grown for their funnel-shaped flowers. Fully hardy. Requires sun or shade and deep, well-drained soil. Propagate by division in spring or by seed in fall.

M. echioides. Clump-forming perennial. H 6–9in (15–23cm), S 6in (15cm). Has basal rosettes of long, ovate, hairy, blue-green leaves. Slender stems carry many open funnel-shaped, dark blue flowers in summer. Z6–9

M. maritima illus. p.356.

M. pulmonarioides. See *M. virginica*.

M. virginica, syn. *M. pulmonarioides*, illus. p.261.

MERWILLA

ASPARAGACEAE

Genus of bulbs (ranging from dwarf to tall) grown for their foliage and spikes of blue flowers produced in summer. Half-hardy to frost tender. Grows in well-drained soil in full sun. Propagate by division when dormant or by seed in fall.

M. plumbea, syn. *Scilla natalensis*. Clump-forming, summer-flowering bulb. H 12–48in (30–120cm), S 3in (8cm). Has lance-shaped, semierect, finely hairy basal leaves with a long spike of up to 100 small, flattish, pale violet-blue, pink or white flowers. Z10–11

MERYTA

ARALIACEAE

Genus of evergreen trees, grown for their handsome foliage. Frost tender. Requires full light or partial shade and humus-rich,